



CoARA Action Plan

University of Zurich

I. Organizational Context

External and Internal Policies

As the largest university in Switzerland with the broadest range of disciplines, the University of Zurich (UZH) has been active for many years in various national and international networks concerned with developing the conditions in which research takes place, most importantly the Swiss Rectors' Conference *swissuniversities*¹ and the League of European Research Universities (LERU).² Since the **San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA)**,³ which UZH signed in 2014, the opportunities to discuss shortcomings and possible approaches in the area of **Research Assessment (RA)** in particular and in the vast field of **Research Culture** in general have multiplied. Specific concerns related to **Open Science (OS)** have significantly shaped the debates in recent years. Further momentum comes from the expectation that research-performing institutions should guarantee **Equality, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI)**. In addition to and inspired by these international and national developments and corresponding recommendations, UZH has published two internal policies with participation of internal stakeholders: the **UZH Diversity Policy** (2018)⁴ and the **UZH Open Science Policy** (2021).⁵ Both policies are still an important basis for the endeavor to promote cultural change and to establish the necessary processes and services at UZH.

RA, OS, EDI and Research Culture naturally overlap as strategic agendas and areas of reform. The present Action Plan, which UZH has drawn up as a signatory of the **Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA)**,⁶ nevertheless focuses on issues specifically relating to RA as far as possible.

Structural Features

UZH has a **highly decentralized** governance structure: The Executive Board oversees the central university services and the seven faculties,⁷ but the faculties have a large degree of autonomy in many respects. Regulations and policies that affect the entire university are usually developed in a combination of **top-down** and **bottom-up** approaches, aiming at decisions and guidelines that are as consistent and standardized as possible and, at the same time, have the best chances to be supported and implemented in the manifold discipline-specific research realities and cultures. Faculties then design their own standards in line with the university-wide framework. This is particularly evident in the recruitment and promotion of research personnel, which lies at the heart of RA for universities.

¹ www.swissuniversities.ch/en/

² www.leru.org

³ www.sfdora.org

⁴ www.uzh.ch/en/explore/basics/responsibility/diversity.html

⁵ www.zenodo.org/records/5602816

⁶ www.coara.eu/agreement/the-agreement-full-text/

⁷ In this document, the term "faculty" (pl "faculties") refers to an organizational unit. Professors are referred to as "members of the faculty"; www.uzh.ch/en/explore/faculties.html.

II. Development, Approach and Structure of this Action Plan

Development and Approach

The present Action Plan is based on surveys and workshops with **central services** involved in the topic of research assessment (see list below), and on a comprehensive survey of representatives from all seven **faculties**, who were nominated as ARRA point of contact by their respective Faculty Board. In most cases, the representatives were the Vice Deans for Research. In this way, a mapping was created of what is currently underway, what is planned and what the next steps are in relation to the ten commitments of the ARRA.

The decentralized structure of UZH thus determined the process of developing this Action Plan and is also evident in the results, i.e. in the concrete actions listed in the third part of this document. The workshops and surveys clearly showed that top-down regulations and initiatives would be an inadequate approach. The faculties strongly advocated that guidelines for RA should be developed from within the disciplinary cultures, whereby centrally developed policies and tools should provide orientation, support and represent at most general boundary conditions. It also became clear that there are reservations about a further policy initiative, which largely overlaps with ongoing activities and agendas (see section "External and Internal Policies"). Accordingly, this Action Plan is first and foremost an overview of what central and decentralized units⁸ have initiated or planned so far. However, it includes some elements of future action and, in addition to sharing best practices with other universities, serves to promote mutual learning and ongoing reflection about RA within UZH.

Structure

The primary structure of the Action Plan is based on the distinction between **three assessment levels**, which are also repeatedly referred to in the ARRA:⁹ the assessment of **research projects**, of **individual researchers** and of **research performing organizations** or units. The secondary structure is created by specific **action fields** (listed in the colored rows of the tables) that have emerged as common denominators of the many different actions that were collected in the surveys. Within these action fields, measures that are **ongoing** are listed first, followed by those that are already **planned**, and finally those that are **next steps to be taken**. **Next steps** refer to future actions that are considered desirable by stakeholders, but whose implementation will also require prioritization at the expense of other tasks, or additional human or financial resources. The numbers in brackets at the end of each action indicate for which of the **ten commitments of the AARA**¹⁰ the respective action is relevant. Where reference is made to central services, the abbreviations of the respective units involved are given in brackets, too (in alphabetic order): Evaluation Office (EO), Graduate Campus (GRC), Human Resources (HR), Office for Equality, Diversity and Inclusion (EDI), Open Science Services (OSS), Professorships Department (PD), Research & Grants Office (R&GO), Strategic Projects, University Medicine Zurich (UMZH).

⁸ "Decentralized units" refers to the faculties with their dean's offices and their departments. "Central services" refers to departments that are not assigned to a faculty, but directly to a member of the Executive Board of the University and whose work is aimed at the entire university.

⁹ See the preliminary remarks on page 2 of the full text version of the Agreement:
www.coara.eu/app/uploads/2022/09/2022_07_19_rra_agreement_final.pdf.

¹⁰ The ten commitments read as follows: **1:** Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research; **2:** Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators; **3:** Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index; **4:** Avoid the use of rankings of research organizations in research assessment; **5:** Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organizational changes committed to; **6:** Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes; **7:** Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use; **8:** Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition; **9:** Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments; **10:** Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research; see www.coara.eu/agreement/the-commitments/.

III. Action Plan

1. Assessment of Research Projects

At UZH, research activities are primarily funded at the decentralized level by faculty members' basic funds. Additional research funds are allocated on a competitive basis through internal research funding programs, most of which are administered by central units. Project or proposal assessment mainly takes place in the context of these programs: The evaluation process is designed and managed by central services, the reviews are carried out by faculty members or external reviewers (assigned by central services or faculty members). These programs cover both individual career grants and collaborative network grants. Most of the reviews in the category of individual career grants are carried out by the members of the UZH Research Committee.¹¹ In addition, there are standing faculty committees as well as central and decentralized ad hoc panels. Collaborative network grants are often evaluated by external reviewers.

Action	Status
1.1 Consider and promote diverse types of outputs	
Assessment frameworks for centrally funded programs, particularly in the category of collaborative network grants, integrate a broad range of research outputs. This will be maintained and continuously improved along with international best practice (R&GO, Strategic Projects UMZH) (1).	Ongoing
Central services (R&GO, Strategic Projects UMZH) clarify how to integrate the principles of the UZH Open Science Policy ¹² into the eligibility and evaluation criteria for internal funding schemes (both in the category of individual career grants and collaborative network grants). The funding schemes are gradually being adjusted in line with these findings (1, 6).	Ongoing
With its long-term financial and structural support for Citizen Science Zurich (CSZ), ¹³ UZH is investing in a One-Stop-Shop that supports researchers in carrying out high-quality citizen science projects, thus contributing to public engagement and co-creation in research (1).	Ongoing
1.2 Promote and improve qualitative assessment and supplement it with targeted use of quantitative assessment	
Central services (GRC, R&GO, Strategic Projects UMZH) constantly work on improving the assessment templates for internal funding schemes to provide reviewers with clear manuals that list and explain the qualitative and quantitative evaluation criteria and are easy to adhere to even under (time) pressure (2, 3). ♦ Example: The new rating scales on the evaluation platform for centrally managed grants (myUZHGrants) provide detailed descriptions of the individual scores.	Ongoing
When designing assessment procedures for internal project funding, central services (R&GO) create structures for high-quality feedback to applicants, with the aim of valuing peer-review and enhancing transparency (2,7).	Ongoing

¹¹ www.research.uzh.ch/en/vp/Research-And-Grants-Office/researchcommittee.html

¹² www.zenodo.org/records/5602816

¹³ www.citizenscience.uzh.ch/en.html

Central services (R&GO) and decentralized units explore ways to enhance the recognition for the work of the UZH Research Committee (2).	Next steps
1.3 Provide guidance and training on assessment criteria in line with the directions for the development of assessment outlined above¹⁴	
Information on evaluation bodies and evaluation criteria of all centrally funded programs is published online. All call documents and assessment templates (evaluation criteria, evaluation forms, etc.) of the centrally administered programs are made available both to grant applicants and reviewers (GRC, R&GO) (7).	Ongoing
Current trends in research assessment are covered in courses on how to write a grant proposal for third-party funding for early career researchers (GRC) (7).	Ongoing
Whenever possible, early career researchers actively participate in the evaluation of applications for internal funding schemes and awards and thereby gain knowledge and experience in the domain of research assessment (GRC, R&GO) (7). ♦ Examples: UZH Mentoring Award, UZH Postdoc Team Award, GRC Career Grants.	Ongoing
With the creation of a new Research Synthesis Center, ¹⁵ UZH contributes to the foundations of an assessment culture that values the quality of research instead of the number of publications. The center will support and train researchers in creating methodologically sound and reproducible study designs (1, 3, 7).	Planned
Central services (R&GO) organize in-depth trainings for the members of the UZH Research Committee and for ad hoc reviewers with the aim of improving the validity of peer-review processes (7).	Planned
1.4 Constantly improve our assessment procedures according to international best practice	
Central services (GRC, R&GO) advance the standardization of the assessment frameworks, tools, processes and templates across the different internal funding lines (6, 10).	Ongoing
Decentralized units organize meetings and discussion on how to improve their evaluation practices, with support from central services, if requested (6). ♦ Example: The Faculty of Law is considering the ARRA as an opportunity to review its own evaluation culture during a retreat of the Faculty Council in June 2025.	Planned
Central services (R&GO) promote mutual learning among decentralized units (8). ♦ Example: The Research & Grants Office (R&GO) organizes workshops with members of the UZH Research Committee to harmonize evaluation procedures.	Planned
Central services (R&GO) in collaboration with all faculties mandate data scientists (ideally internal experts from the Center for Reproducible Science, CRS, or the CHES) to study the strengths and weaknesses of the current assessment frameworks (central and decentralized) in order to design evidence-based reforms (tailored research on research (RoR)) (10).	Next steps

¹⁴ In action fields 1.1 and 1.2.

¹⁵ The new center will build on the existing Center for Reproducible Science (CRS); www.crs.uzh.ch/en.html.

2. Assessment of Individual Researchers

At UZH, the recruitment and promotion of researchers up to and including the postdoctoral level is carried out decentrally by the PIs and/or the Graduate Schools (in the case of doctoral candidates). On a technical level, the central Human Resources department (HR) is responsible for the contracts of all employees, including doctoral candidates, postdocs and academic staff, whereas the Professorships Department (PD) is in charge of HR matters relating to professors. Doctoral candidates – whether employed or not – conclude doctoral agreements with their supervisors, outlining milestones and mutual expectations, in line with centrally defined guidelines. The (research) performance of all employees and doctoral candidates up to and including postdoctoral level is assessed as part of the annual employee (performance) appraisals or career discussions. The appointment and promotion of professors is carried out by the seven Faculties,¹⁶ the Executive Board and the Board of the University, with support of the PD.¹⁷

Action	Status
2.1 Consider diverse types of outputs and career paths at all career levels	
The importance of recognizing diverse activities (incl. teaching, leadership, training, mentoring) is highlighted in courses on supervision for professors and postdocs as well as in courses on leadership skills for postdocs and PhDs, which are offered by central services (GRC) (1).	Ongoing
The recently established Data Stewards Network, coordinated by OSS, connects researchers and employees that are committed to FAIR and open data. The network promotes a dialogue between Data Stewards from various disciplines, helps them gain access to information about relevant regulations and best practices and contributes to the recognition of the work of research support staff (1, 7).	Ongoing
The UZH Mentoring Award showcases good supervision of doctoral candidates at UZH. The award will continue to be presented every second year (GRC) (1, 7).	Ongoing
Central services (GRC) foster recognition of practices that contribute to robustness, openness and transparency through different courses for early career researchers in transferable skills and with events that inform directly on transparency practices (1, 7). ♦ Example: GRC organizes the Open Science Summer School every two years and regularly offers a course in transferable skills on Good Research Practice.	Ongoing
Central services (GRC) raise awareness on the topic of qualitative research assessment among various stakeholders (2, 7). ♦ Examples: GRC organizes courses on how to become appointable ("Berufungstraining") that address topics related to qualitative research assessment.	Ongoing
Central services (HR) include and promote the newly developed guidelines for assessing diverse types of research performance in annual career discussions in addition to the revised UZH annual employee (performance) appraisal material. These guidelines are relevant for all employees except professors (1, 6).	Planned

¹⁶ www.uzh.ch/en/explore/faculties.html

¹⁷ Further information on the appointment procedures at UZH can be found here: www.prof.uzh.ch/en/welcome/appointment_procedure.

The implementation of UZH's Open Science Policy will be promoted in a new roadmap, coordinated by the central unit Open Science Services (OSS). The roadmap includes strengthening the skills of UZH researchers and increasing the visibility and appreciation of Open Science aspects of research in assessment procedures (1, 7).	Planned
2.2 Consider diverse types of outputs and career paths at PhD level	
A template for doctoral agreements at UZH ¹⁸ includes activities that go beyond regular research and teaching duties and covers aspects of Open Science and Open Research Data. It was recently introduced, and its use will be monitored in the years to come (1, 6) (GRC).	Planned
Central services (GRC) organize an information session on the ARRA commitments for coordinators of doctoral programs and graduate schools (1, 9).	Planned
2.3 Consider diverse types of outputs and career paths at postdoctoral level	
A working group (Lead: GRC) is mapping, analyzing and benchmarking different career paths that researchers at UZH take after the PhD (both in and outside academia), with the aim of clarifying and harmonizing career opportunities (in terms of expectations, recognition and employment conditions) across the university (1).	Ongoing
2.4 Consider diverse types of outputs and avoid use of inappropriate metrics at professorial level	
As part of the project HI-Frame, ¹⁹ central services (EDI) and decentralized units have developed a systematic guide on how to recognize Open Science practices when hiring professorial staff. As a basis for the broad implementation of the questionnaire, central services (OSS) are initiating projects that aim at providing information on data (especially open data) and software, in addition to already available information on the proportion of open access publications (1, 6). ♦ Example: Development of a Current Research Information System (CRIS).	Ongoing
UZH has adopted "Guidelines on Selection Procedures in Professorial Appointments" ²⁰ in 2018 which recognize UZH's commitment to DORA. This is supplemented by guidelines on appointment and promotion procedures developed and implemented by the individual faculties. The existing guidelines will be reviewed with regard to the ARRA and amended if necessary (PD) (1, 2, 3).	Next steps
Decentralized units develop discipline-specific answers to the question in which cases the use of publication metrics is appropriate and explore possible alternatives for those cases in which quantitative metrics are inappropriate. The UZH-internal Working Group Open	Next steps

¹⁸ www.graduates.uzh.ch/en/Dokumente.html

¹⁹ www.openscience.uzh.ch/en/open-science-at-uzh/p5-open-science-projects/projects-2021-2024/hi-frame.html

²⁰ www.prof.uzh.ch/dam/jcr:a5146bcc-847a-4b83-8213-137115ea62ff/Guidelines_Selection_Procedures.pdf

Science led by OSS and with representatives of all seven faculties will be a suitable forum to kickstart this discussion (2, 3, 4).

3. Assessment of Research Performing Organizations/Units

In 2000, the University of Zurich established its Evaluation Office. It is tasked with evaluating all of UZH's approximately 200 organizational units at intervals of six to eight years. The purpose of the evaluations is, among others, to survey and further develop the quality of academic work. The evaluations are executed in a multi-stage procedure, including self- and external evaluation. With its Center for Higher Education and Science Studies (CHESS),²¹ UZH conducts internationally recognized research in the field of higher education and science studies and thereby pools relevant expertise for a high-quality self-reflection of the institution.

Action	Status
3.1 Promote qualitative assessment methods and avoid the inappropriate use of metrics	
The Evaluation Office uses only field-normalized, publication-related indicators (ESI-fields). Since 2023, bibliometric analyses are minimized and information on Open Access (OA) is included in the report of evaluated units (3). ◆ After every evaluation, the external experts get asked for feedback on the process. Subjective evaluation of publications is carried out in the self-evaluation report, highlighting the most important publications from the perspective of the units. Detailed bibliometric analyses are only performed for units where it is appropriate or mostly appropriate; otherwise, a lighter bibliometric approach is used, covering the number of publications, languages, proportion of Open Access, and journals in which publications most frequently appear.	Ongoing
All key steps during an evaluation process are carried out through discussions: preliminary talks, evaluation agreement discussions, talks between the evaluated parties and experts, strategy and development discussions (agreement on measures and monitoring) and through written reports (self-evaluation and expert reports) (7).	Ongoing
The evaluation office increases the level of qualitative methods in its processes (7). ◆ The template for the self-evaluation report will be adapted: The research section will focus even more on quality (instead of "5 most important publications", researchers are asked for "Most Important Research Output" (publications, data collection, software, etc.) and to justify their choice in a few sentences). ◆ In addition to surveys done prior to the expert assessment, as a substitute for written surveys, focus group discussions with predefined topics will be part of the process.	Ongoing
3.2 Avoid the use of rankings	
In 2024, UZH decided to withdraw from the Times Higher Education World University Ranking (THE Ranking), arguing that the ranking is unable to reflect the wide range of teaching and research activities undertaken by universities. The Evaluation Office still supplies data for other rankings but also provides background information on the rankings and explains the problematic sides of the ranking results to internal and external interested parties. UZH has decided to join the European Higher Education Sector Observatory (EHESO),²² a data and information platform on the higher education sector in Europe. By consolidating	Ongoing

²¹ www.chess.uzh.ch/en.html

²² <https://national-policies.eacea.ec.europa.eu/eheso>

and integrating various openly available data sources, the Observatory provides a transparent view of European higher education systems, institutional profiles and indicators. It follows the U-Multirank and enables the comparison, analysis, and showcasing of the sector's performance based on multidimensional standards (4).	
UZH has decided not to allow organizational or strategic decisions to be influenced by ranking considerations (4). ♦ Rankings are not considered in the evaluation processes carried out by the Evaluation Office.	Ongoing
With the support of the central services (EO), faculties and departments develop a position in which cases the use of rankings is appropriate in their domains and in which cases decisions should not be based on rankings, and develop strategies to enforce this distinction in practice (4).	Next steps
3.3 Constantly improve the quality of assessment procedures, according to international best practice	
The CHESS continues to establish its advisory services for central services. The Leadership and Governance Academy (LGA) provides leadership training offers. The LGA plays a crucial role in the development of UZH's leadership culture (5).	Ongoing
The Evaluation Office reviews its processes regularly and adjusts them where appropriate (6). ♦ Example: After every evaluation, the external experts are asked for feedback on the process in a questionnaire.	Ongoing
The Evaluation Office regularly consults a data scientist to consistently improve its procedures and tools (10).	Ongoing

4 General Actions on all Assessment Levels

Some action lines concern several or all of the three assessment levels (assessment of **research projects**, of **individual researchers** and of **research performing organizations**). These are listed below.

Action	Status
Central services regularly exchange on best practices with peers at national and international level (8). ♦ At national level: Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF); correspondent central services at other Swiss universities; Qualitätsnetzwerk der universitären Hochschulen der Schweiz (Q-Netzwerk); CoARA-related bodies. ♦ At international level: other member universities within League of European Research Universities (LERU), U21 and the European University Alliance Una Europa, strategic alliance between Berlin, Vienna and Zurich.	Ongoing
Central services (R&GO) incorporate findings from recORD ²³ into assessment frameworks, tools and processes wherever possible (1).	Planned
Central services (R&GO, GRC, HR, PD) and faculties develop and implement a common CV template which considers diverse types of outputs, achievements and roles, based on the	Next steps

²³ recORD was a project supported by the federal program P5 Open Science (SERI, swissuniversities), running for one year (2024). It aimed at a national commitment on how Open Research Data (ORD) should be recognized in research assessment (assessment of projects, individuals, institutions/units); www.forscenter.ch/projects/swissuniversities-record/.



experiences and findings of national and international research performing institutions and funding agencies with narrative CV formats (1, 6, 8, 2) .	
Central services (GRC, PD, R&GO) and decentralized units design and implement further training possibilities, starting at the postdoctoral level, on how to perform research assessment (peer review procedures and evaluation of individuals for promotion) (1) .	Next steps
Central services (GRC) offer courses for early career researchers on how to write a narrative CV (7) .	Next steps

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